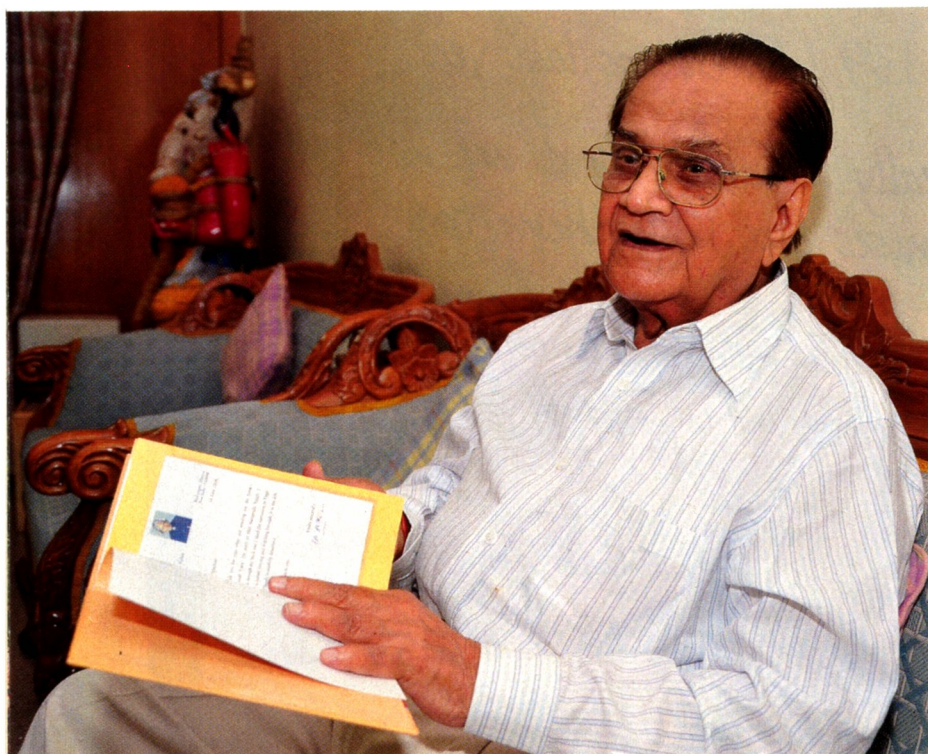


SAMPRADA SINGH

82, PHARMACEUTICALS MANUFACTURER
CHAIRMAN, A L K E M G R O U P
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1973 Rs 5 lakh
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,200 crore



KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

secret of his SUCCESS

Ambition, positive thinking and plain old hard work

fitness MANTRA

An early riser, Singh practises yoga religiously every day

looks UP TO

Jayaprakash Narayan and Swami Vivekananda

THE RIGHT CHEMISTRY

Going by his background, his village, Okri in Jehanabad, Bihar, would have nominated Samprada Singh as the person least likely to succeed. In 1937, at the age of 11, he was part of a mob that set a police station on fire under British India. He was expelled from his school hostel in 1945 for another of his numerous acts of rebellion.

In 1950, after completing his B.Com, he decided to make money and armed with borrowed capital and government subsidy, purchased a pump set with the intention of becoming a farmer. Virtually everyone in the family and the village gave him up as a lost cause after a famine in the area put an end to his agricultural ambitions.

Samprada's name means wealth and

prosperity but for many years, it didn't look like he was ever going to achieve that. In 1952, with no income of his own, Singh was forced to join Pandui High School as a teacher. His tenure there lasted 10 days. Having returned home—by now he was also a father—the pressure was getting unbearable. He was again forced to take a job he didn't want: as a clerk. Again, he quit after just 10 days and got into umbrella retail with a friend—something that gave him reasonable returns during the monsoon but offered nothing once the rains were over.

In 1953, he convinced Sitaram Singh, his partner in the umbrella business, to open a medicine shop. He became a retail chemist but the profit from the shop was shared by the partners and hence his share was meagre. By now, he knew enough of the drug business to approach a relative, Parmeshwar Singh, with a proposal. With Parmeshwar's money and Samprada's expertise, they established Lakshmi Pharmaceuticals, a drug distribution agency. It failed in less than a year. Undeterred, Samprada set up Magadh Pharmaceuticals to start an independent drug distribution business in Patna.

But his big chance was to come in 1970 when he moved to Mumbai with all his savings. There, he along with two partners, pooled in Rs 5 lakh to establish a drug manufacturing company. Samprada's contribution was Rs 1.5 lakh. Even this partnership did not last because of mutual mistrust, but the seeds of future success had been sown. In 1973, aged 47, he set up Alkem Laboratories Limited. The business grew steadily and today, Alkem is one of the top 10 players in the domestic pharmaceutical market. Success, however, has not slowed him down. In 2004, 31 years after launching Alkem, the 78-year-old patriarch spearheaded a move into food processing and health-oriented products.

For many in the industry, Singh's success has been baffling because he still remains a simple man—he doesn't know how to send an SMS or operate a laptop. What he does know is invaluable: that adversity can sometimes push you to extraordinary heights.

by Amitabh Srivastava